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# School autonomy, marketisation and social justice: the plight of principals and schools

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## ABSTRACT

There remains strong political support for school autonomy reform within Australian public education despite evidence linking this reform to exacerbating school and systemic inequities. This paper presents interview data from key education stakeholders gathered from a broader study that is investigating the social justice implications of school autonomy reform across three Australian states. We focus on the concerns these stakeholders raise about the plight of principals and particular schools when policies of school autonomy converge with market imperatives of economic efficiency, competition and public accountability. Such concerns reflect the significance of education systems providing greater and more nuanced support for principals and schools to manage the extra responsibilities of greater school autonomy and accountability. While these aspects of support are central, we argue that systemic reform that is driven by educative, rather than market, imperatives is necessary for creating a context where school autonomy can be mobilised for social justice.

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## Introduction

Increasing school autonomy has been a feature of the different state public education systems in Australia under various guises for decades. In education policy discourse, greater school autonomy is aligned with the freedoms requisite for schools to innovate and drive up academic standards. While there remains strong political support for this reform in Australia (as there is elsewhere), greater school autonomy has not unilaterally led to school improvement as measured by student outcomes (Musset 2012). Indeed, there is evidence indicating that this reform continues to exacerbate inequity within and between schools and their systems (Blackmore 1999; Smyth 2011). This paper explores the equity implications of school autonomy reform within Australia's public education system. We draw on interview data gathered from 42 key education stakeholders across three states, Western Australia, Victoria and New South Wales. The paper identifies and analyses the views expressed by these stakeholders about the negative equity implications of school autonomy reform when it is driven by market imperatives. We focus,

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in particular, on the concerns these stakeholders raise about the plight of principals and particular schools when policies of school autonomy converge with market imperatives of economic efficiency, competition and public accountability. Such concerns reflect the significance of education systems (at regional and state levels) providing greater support for principals to manage the extra responsibilities and pressures of greater school autonomy and accountability. They also reflect the significance of a more nuanced approach to supporting particular schools struggling to mobilise the ‘freedoms’ of this reform in ways that adequately support their students. These aspects of systemic support are central. However, like key research before us, we view systemic reform that is driven by educative and equity imperatives, rather than market imperatives, as necessary for creating a context where school autonomy can be mobilised in socially just ways.

### **School autonomy reform and Australian public education**

There has been a long history of school autonomy reform in Australia’s public education systems. This reform has differed markedly across state jurisdictions under various guises from self-managing schools in Victoria in the 1990s to *Local Schools Local Decisions* rolled out in New South Wales (NSW) between 2011 and 2018, to the introduction of Independent Public Schools (IPS) in Western Australia (WA) from 2010 and Queensland from 2013. Despite a lack of evidence linking greater school autonomy with improved student outcomes (Musset 2012), there remains strong political support for this reform. For example, in 2015 the conservative federal government committed \$70 million to ‘build on current developments across the states to help schools become more autonomous and independent if they so choose’ (Australian Government 2016). The continuing commitment to school autonomy reform (mirrored in similar reforms in England with the Academies movements, the USA with Charter schools and Sweden with Free Schools) (Gunter 2011; Lipman 2011; Lundahl et al. 2013) is rooted in a belief that granting schools greater freedom will lead to school improvement (Cobbold 2013; Gobby 2013; Wilkinson, Niesche, and Eacott 2018). This is usually seen to be achievable primarily through devolving decisions over funding, with principals responsible for a single global budget. Theoretically, this allows them to gain some discretionary capacity over staffing, resourcing and the types of programmes offered. Such discretion, however, is still bound by national policies on curriculum, equity and funding and accountability to state and federal governments through school reviews, reporting and standardised assessment of learning outcomes.

When considering how school autonomy reform is shaped by the market imperatives of economic efficiency, competition and choice, and governance demands for external auditing, its negative impacts become apparent. The imperatives of economic rationalism accompanying school autonomy reform have tended to decimate the structures, resources and programmes of central education bureaucracies traditionally associated with supporting public schools. In Western Australia, as similarly occurred in Victoria in the 1990s (Blackmore et al. 1996), such imperatives have led to a dismantling of bureaucratic structures of school support at the regional level with dire consequences for small, rural and remote schools (in terms of a decimation of support). Such has been the case in other western contexts, like England, where in the name of school autonomy reform, i.e. the Academies movement and earlier Self-governing Schools (Gunter 2011), the regional

supports of the state education system (i.e. Local Education Authorities) have been whittled away leaving schools to manage obligations (e.g. the academic, health and well-being needs of students) previously the responsibility of the state (Ball and Junemann 2012; Smyth 2011). To survive within this environment of decreased funding and the pressures of economic efficiency, many schools are turning to parent and local community fundraising (Rowe and Perry 2019, 2020), and the philanthropic and corporate sectors to meet shortfalls, the latter raising significant issues around conflict of interest and lack of accountability.

Such survival is instrumentally tied to high stakes testing and public accountability – the instating and increased significance of both in Australia (and elsewhere) have been driven by the idea that competition (in relation to school performance) will drive up standards and public accountability will enable consumers (e.g. parents and students) choice between schools. The My School website provides demographic information about all Australian schools with a particular focus on comparing schools on the basis of their NAPLAN standardised test scores, a comparison recently modified from allowing a comparison with adjacent schools to comparing individual schools to Australia-wide data. It was instated in Australia in 2008 – a key rationale was to provide transparency about school quality for parents to support an informed choice of school for their children (Doolan and Blackmore 2018; Lingard, Sellar, and Savage 2014). This market accountability model assumes failing schools with reducing parental demand will close regardless of local need while succeeding schools will thrive. This model has increased stratification and residualisation within the public system – i.e. through valuing (publicly rewarding) and de-valuing (publicly shaming) schools on the basis of their academic test performance (Doolan and Blackmore 2018; Lamb et al. 2015). Further compounding this stratification is the relationship between a school's positioning (e.g. location, social mix, level of disadvantage) and its capacity to attract and maintain quality principals and teachers across all subject areas (Mayer et al. 2017). This situation is exacerbated in rural/remote and under-performing schools which are already difficult to staff (Sullivan, Perry, and McConney 2014; Downes and Roberts 2018). These experiences are mirrored in other countries such as Nordic countries where rural and remote schools experience difficulties in relation to hierarchisation as in Australia (Beach et al. 2019; Cuervo 2016).

The work of school leaders is said to be the most powerful mediating force in determining how school autonomy plays out and is especially important in building professional capacity through staff selection, professional development and priority setting (Caldwell 2015; Melbourne Graduate School of Education 2013). School leadership will shape how autonomy and accountability are combined (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development 2011). The demands associated with principals' work are, however, constantly escalating and principals are under considerable stress (compromising their health and wellbeing) (Australian Primary Principals Association 2017; Riley 2018; Winkler 2016; Heffernan and Pierpoint 2020). In smaller and rural schools and more disadvantaged communities there are fewer resources and greater needs (e.g. in relation to adequately supporting students and teachers) (Anderson and White 2011; DeMatthews 2015; Møller 2012). These schools do not fare as well as more advantaged schools in devolved systems (given they require more support than is readily available, e.g. through the community, parents, etc.). Principals in these schools thus may experience

higher workloads and greater stress than in more advantaged schools (Day 2014; MacDonald 2019).

Against this backdrop, this paper draws attention to the concerns expressed by key education stakeholders about school autonomy reform when it is driven by market imperatives with a particular focus on the plight of principals and particular schools.

## Research context and processes

The data presented in this paper derive from a three-year Australian Research Council study that is exploring the social justice implications of school autonomy reform across four states in Australia: Queensland (Qld), Victoria (Vic), Western Australia (WA) and New South Wales (NSW). The study is examining how school autonomy is understood by key education stakeholders in Australia; how it is enacted in Australian public schools; and the implications of this enactment for social justice. In this paper we present findings from the first year of the research from interviews with 42 stakeholders including representatives from educational bureaucracies (12); politics (3); parent organisations (3); principal associations (7); principals (4); professional organisations (3); academics (4) and teacher unions (6). These stakeholders represented: Victoria (14); NSW (8); Qld (8); and WA (10) with two stakeholders representing national viewpoints (See Table 1).

In referring to these stakeholders in the following sections, we identify the state they are associated with and their role, but to protect anonymity, we do not identify their position and we allocate pseudonyms. We present findings associated with three of the four states: WA, Vic and NSW. In this paper we do not include data from Qld given that in this state, the roll out of school autonomy in the form of the IPS initiative has paused following an evaluation of its efficacy, i.e. that greater autonomy granted to some schools had not improved school outcomes (Potential+Solutions Business Consulting and Executive Coaching, 2018).

The interviews were conducted over several months in 2019 by the project team of seven researchers. All interviews (usually from 60–90 min long) involved two researchers to maintain consistency and one, or sometimes two, interviewees and were conducted either face-to-face or online. The interviews were focused on exploring the participants' understandings of school autonomy including the origins and development of this idea in Australia and more specifically the state they were located in; the renewed focus nationally and internationally on school autonomy reform; the impacts of this reform at the school and system level in terms of social justice (e.g. in relation to decision making, the allocation of resources and differential benefits regarding student outcomes, leadership practices and teachers' work); important factors for mobilising school autonomy in productive ways; and the role of regional and other support in autonomous systems.

The data were initially analysed using Nvivo. Coding was driven by the key concepts explored in the research such as 'school autonomy', 'social justice', 'equity', 'public schooling', 'accountability' and 'decision-making' (as highlighted in the interview questions noted above). In this paper we focus on the concepts of 'social justice' and 'equity' which broadly included all stakeholder comments about these areas but tended to focus on the fair and equitable distribution of material and human resources (see Fraser 2009).

**Table 1.** School autonomy and social justice project stakeholders.

| States   | Academic | Education<br>Bureaucrat | Politician | Peak Parent<br>Organisation | Principal<br>Association | Principal | Professional<br>Organisation | Union<br>Delegate | Total |
|----------|----------|-------------------------|------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------|-----------|------------------------------|-------------------|-------|
| National | 1        |                         |            |                             |                          |           |                              |                   | 2     |
| NSW      | 1        | 4                       | 1          |                             |                          | 1         | 1                            | 1                 | 8     |
| Qld      | 1        | 1                       |            | 1                           | 2                        | 1         | 1                            | 1                 | 8     |
| Victoria | 1        | 7                       |            | 1                           | 1                        | 1         | 1                            | 2                 | 14    |
| WA       |          |                         | 2          | 1                           | 4                        | 1         |                              | 2                 | 10    |
| Total    | 4        | 12                      | 3          | 3                           | 7                        | 4         | 3                            | 6                 | 42    |

We were deliberate in trying to select a range of stakeholders from different roles who could express different perspectives in relation to this reform. However, we acknowledge the limitations of our sample in not being representative of all views about school autonomy across Australia. This would be impossible especially given the complex policies and histories of this reform and their enactment in the different states involved in the study. While our presentation of these perspectives here is necessarily partial, what we seek to capture are the key concerns about issues of equity and social justice as stakeholders construed these issues and their resonance with other research in this space. These key concerns will be further explored in the second year of the study with follow up case studies across the three states.

Data analysis was an iterative process that involved exploring how stakeholder concerns resonated with and could be explained in relation to the broader literature about the equity implications of school autonomy reform (outlined in the previous sections). This process brought to light a generally positive view of school autonomy per se but a recognition of how it was curtailed by the market imperatives of competition and economic efficiency with particularly negative effects for principals and disadvantaged schools. We focus on these areas in the following sections.

## Views about school autonomy

Most of the stakeholders expressed support for the idea of greater school autonomy. Mentioned here, and consistent with the research in this space, were the capacities of this reform to reflect political justice in its focus on localised school decision making and economic justice when the reform was supported with adequate state and federal funding and support from the system (see Keddie 2017a). There were many general comments about the flexibilities of this reform to enable schools ‘to tailor their provision’ to students ‘particularly students who needed something extra’ (Boris, politician, NSW); to ‘give schools the opportunity to meet the needs of... the community’ (Erin, principal, NSW); and as enabling ‘flexibility’ in curriculum and pedagogy and the deployment of resources (Miriam and Kyle, bureaucrats, NSW; Uberta, bureaucrat, Vic) especially in relation to issues of staffing and professional learning (Jack, principal association, WA). Tony (principal association, WA) spoke about how the flexibilities of this reform could ‘soften the inequities in our system and society in general’ when resources were allocated for equity programmes (e.g. to support students with disabilities, assisting students to attend excursions). Many of the stakeholders noted, here, the significance of state and federal equity funding, as working with the flexibilities of school autonomy reform to ‘deliver social justice outcomes’ (Boris, politician, NSW).

## Autonomy within the context of marketisation

... the notion of markets [is] not ... terrific in other domains of adult experience but they are toxic for children – because the sense of a child existing in a market and hierarchy with winners/losers is absolutely antithetical to our understanding of what everyone wants for our young ... (Edward, union, NSW)

While the general idea of school autonomy was supported, Edward's comments here reflect the strong concern expressed across all stakeholder groups about the ways in which market forces had taken hold of, and degraded, public education in Australia. Consistent with the literature reviewed earlier (see Lamb et al. 2015), such concerns were associated with the negative impacts of competition and rigid external accountabilities. Participants viewed the My School website as instrumental in creating this climate. Edward (union, NSW) stated 'you couldn't design something more effective for social division', arguing that in a 'few clicks' users of this site could identify a 'hierarchy of winners and losers.' For Miriam and Kyle (education bureaucrats, NSW) the notion of choice was the 'death knell' of public schooling because it forced schools into 'competing with each other for numbers and principals into competing for their salary'. It had created a 'pecking order' that 'sucked the life out of the system.' Edward similarly explained that competition and external accountability within the public schooling system in Australia had increased 'social segregation' where schools 'become residualised' and where hierarchies are formed around notions of difference such as language, culture and 'increasingly religion', adding that 'market forces allow that to happen'. Such residualisation was worsened, as Charles (principal, Vic) commented (as did many other stakeholders), when schools turned particular students (seen as too difficult or too needy) away to attend other 'more appropriate' schools.

Most of the respondents located their views of school 'autonomy' within this climate of competition and external accountability—noting that school autonomy was not really 'autonomy' at all given these boundaries. Concerns here were again consistent with the literature reviewed earlier (see Ball and Junemann 2012). Some stakeholders were highly critical of this reform as 'devolving responsibility away from government ... to the shoulders of individual schools' (Noah, professional organisation, NSW) which undermined the 'collective approach to education' as a 'public good' (Cedric, professional organisation, Vic) and made the work of schools 'much more complex [and] difficult' (Erin, principal, NSW). Others were critical of devolution as a 'withering away of the state' and degrading the influence of departments of education and their provision to schools (Edward, union, NSW). Edward described the Department as a 'mere husk' of what it was (before policies of devolution) with particular consequences for equity (e.g. removing equity units and regional/rural support services). Delia (union, National) and Nancy (union, Vic) referring to the WA context, commented similarly that 'under the guise of autonomy and devolution' funding cuts to the Department decimated its 'bureaucratic structure' and 'left schools bereft of that critical advice or support that they need to deal with a whole range of equity issues'.

Informed by these views, stakeholders across all three states expressed particular concern with (1) how principals (especially those with a lack of experience) were not adequately supported to manage the responsibilities and pressures of greater school autonomy and accountability and (2) how particular schools (especially small schools and schools in



rural, remote and disadvantaged areas) despite extra centralised assistance, lacked capacity to mobilise the ‘freedoms’ of this reform in ways that adequately supported their students.

## The plight of principals

Many of the stakeholders expressed concern about the budgetary autonomy afforded to principals and, in particular, the lack of centralised accountability and transparency in relation to this autonomy. As Edward (union, NSW) explained: ‘we don’t have departments knowing how that money is spent. And we would want it spent in socially just ways’. Noah (professional organisation, NSW) noted similar concerns: ‘nobody knows, except the principal’ where these funds are allocated, ‘because it is not transparent’. Regarding equity funding, stakeholders stated that while some principals were very consultative with how they distributed this funding (Noah, NSW) and used these funds very effectively to support equity (Charles, Vic), many did not ‘bother consulting teachers’ (Noah) or ‘didn’t really know what to do with’ the funds (Charles, Vic). Noah (and other stakeholders) noted how this affected particular programmes such as those associated with EAL/D support. He described the discretion afforded to principals and the lack of guidelines around how equity funding should be managed and allocated as undermining equity given it was decimating important programmes ‘because there’s no longer any protection around the programme ... so we have really gone backwards at a terrible rate ... in this last couple of years’. He added: ‘what [we] found, of course, is principals are using it for God knows – you know, anything, really, in schools’ depending on what they see as important.

Such concerns are well recognised in key school autonomy research (see Blackmore 1999; Gunter 2011; Thomson 2020). The opacity of governance in devolved systems makes it difficult for departments to account for and monitor how equity funds are expended (see Ball and Junemann 2012; Keddie 2015). Some principals within this context of opacity have mobilised their autonomy in ways that compromise social justice (see Thomson 2020; Keddie 2015). Certainly, the recent IBAC inquiry in the state of Victoria is evidence of this where a rise in the misuse of funds and corrupt practices is attributed to a lack of government regulation and oversight (IBAC 2017).

In this marketized context, as Travis (bureaucrat, Vic) pointed out, principals are pressured to ‘be entrepreneurial, to grow [their] enrolments, to get the best scores’ – in order that they retain or gain status (Thomson 2020; Keddie, Gobby, and Wilkins 2017). Much has been written about current demands for principal entrepreneurialism in the form of self-determination, ambition and drive for success (see Ball 2010). Entrepreneurialism has been strongly advocated in education policy as requisite to creatively and constructively managing the challenges and risks of the performative era (see Woods 2015). However, when driven by competition and economic rationalism, it is seen as compromising principals’ ethical practice (see Fullan 2002; Keddie 2015; Cranston et al. 2010). For Travis (bureaucrat, Vic), these pressures for entrepreneurialism led to ‘goal displacement’ where principals were focused on bettering their individual school rather than improving the system as a whole. He attributed this goal displacement to how principal success is constituted in the present climate:

You know, ‘Who was stood up as Principal of the Year? Who was featured in the newsletter for their system contribution, not the fact that they turned around a struggling school?’ And



it needs to be both. You can't say, 'Oh, well, you know, my school's going to hell in a hand basket but I'm out there having a great time being a system contributor.' (Travis, bureaucrat, Vic)

Stakeholders also expressed concern about the enduring issue of principal workload intensification. Charles (principal, Vic) commented on the 'heavy price' to the health and well-being of 'some principals' given their increasing workloads while Delia (union, National) and Nancy (union, Vic) commented on the 'high stress levels' and 'violence' principals had to 'contend with'. Decades of research into the health and wellbeing impacts of principals' work continues to link work intensification to poor general health and high levels of physical and mental fatigue and stress (Blackmore 1999; Thomson 2009; Heffernan and Pierpoint 2020). Also consistent with this research, many of the stakeholders commented on the difficulty that education systems encountered finding school leaders prepared with, as Doris (principal WA) described it, the requisite 'experience and corporate knowledge and ability to manage' schools, as she explained, 'they haven't got anybody; because there is a deficit in the amount of people'. While Doris mentioned the importance of a centralised focus on recruiting quality principals and the resources devoted to this in WA (similar to the other states), she also noted the inadequacies of these resources in remote schools where principals found it difficult to cope with the isolation. Even with 'budget incentives', Norman (bureaucrat, NSW) noted the difficulties recruiting principals to isolated communities, amplifying existing inequities, as he explained:

Oh, there are huge incentives. I can pay somebody \$250,000 a year to be a principal in certain parts of New South Wales. Nobody would take it ... it is a miserable existence. You are going to be a very lonely person for a very long time.

These issues of principal shortage and reluctance to take up this role are well recognised (see Collins 2006; Thomson 2009) especially in relation to rural and remote schools where principals are more overwhelmed by managerial, administrative and community responsibilities than their metropolitan counter-parts (see Niesche 2013). This difficulty in attracting experienced and quality candidates to the principalship was seen, according to Noah (professional organisation, NSW), as resulting in 'school systems having some principals reaching the position much sooner than what otherwise might be the case'. Most of the stakeholders expressed great concern about the plight of inexperienced principals trying to manage their schools amid the pressures and expectations of the current systems. These inexperienced principals were, according to several stakeholders, concentrated in regional, rural, remote and disadvantaged schools – a perennial issue for such schools (see Downes and Roberts 2018). In Kurt's view (bureaucrat, Vic) this meant that the 'best principals' were in the 'wrong places' (i.e. the metropolitan areas where there was perhaps less complexities of disadvantage) (see Thomson 2009).

### **The plight of particular schools**

Stakeholders also expressed concern about particular schools (especially small schools and schools in rural, remote and disadvantaged areas) despite extra centralised support, as struggling under the processes and expectations of devolution. This is an ongoing concern that is reflected in Australian research (see Lamb 2007) as it is elsewhere (e.g. in England, see Hutchings, Francis, and De Vries 2014) that highlights the negative effects

of devolution on these types of schools. Small schools and schools in remote locations tend to lack the leadership density and resources to cope with the extra responsibilities of devolved systems (see Keddie 2017b) as do low SES schools where higher levels of disadvantage and need are concentrated as a result of residualisation (Smyth 2011). As Erin (principal, NSW) noted, these schools tended to be located ‘in poorer communities’ and are not receiving ‘sufficient’ funding to ‘run’. Kurt (bureaucrat, Vic) provided an example of a rural school that, despite the provision of extra resources through Gonski equity (needs based) funding (Gonski et al. 2018), given its geographic isolation and high Indigenous student population, was unable to access appropriate professional development for teachers (readily available for city schools), as he commented:

So, you can be in a remote Indigenous school and you will get more money per head than a State Government school ... but you don’t get enough to fly those teachers to a regional or metropolitan capital to do regular PD ...

Stakeholders elaborated on the particular difficulties smaller schools and schools in low SES areas experienced trying to cope with the demands of devolution and marketisation given their lower student numbers and resourcing. They were seen as struggling to compete with larger and better resourced schools. Here, stakeholders mentioned the problems of economies of scale that smaller schools struggle with. Several stakeholders from WA expressed concern about this, as Russell (union, WA) commented, with a student cohort of 3,000 ‘you make an absolute killing’ but with a cohort of 400 ‘you have got to restructure’. He explained that smaller schools still needed to ‘offer ATAR [Australian Tertiary Admission Rank] or you completely lose your top kids ... you had to do that because that kept your parents happy and you didn’t have them sending their kids away.’ Many of the stakeholders mentioned the practice of schools drawing on their own resources to enable such curricular offerings and other activities for students. These issues reflect the pressures of a marketized system where schools are forced to compete with each other for their student share to survive (Ball 2010). This places schools in a precarious position and clearly privileges those schools with more resources at their disposal (see Holloway and Keddie 2018).

Inequities associated with the highly varied capacities of different schools to raise funds, was a concern expressed by many of the stakeholders, as Wendy (bureaucrat, Vic) explained:

... it is a class system; very much a class system. So, if a school in the eastern suburbs runs a school fete, they would raise \$30,000, easy. And they would have heaps of parents who would want to be involved, et cetera. A school in the western/southern suburbs might be lucky if they raise \$2,000 and the teachers do most of the work.

Kurt (bureaucrat, Vic) reflected similarly on this issue also noting some schools’ capacity for revenue raising through parental contributions to building funds and international student enrolment. The differential capacity of public schools to generate income from parents is a significant equity concern – as Rowe and Perry’s research (2020) found, schools in high SES areas can yield up to four times more in parent-generated income than schools in low SES areas. For Nancy (union, Vic) a significant problem here is that many schools are using these ‘school-raised funds’ to pay for services and resources that ‘should be funded by the state’ such as staff, a fact highlighted in the Australian

Education Union's State of our Schools survey (Australian Education Union 2018). She explained that schools are using 'inadequate budgets to try and provide' for a 'huge range' of 'external and supplementary supports that they need for their students.' There was a recognition here that some schools (with less parental capacity to financially contribute) were not able to, as Erin (principal, NSW) stated, 'prop up what should have been [a] state responsibility.' Nancy (union, Vic) further noted, 'the system because of the economies of scale, has a much better capacity to be able to provide those services in a much more consistent and regulated way.'

As with difficulties associated with recruiting principals, stakeholders noted the difficulties within rural and remote areas of recruiting experienced and quality staff. Such difficulties are exacerbated by school autonomy policies where responsibility for staffing is devolved to schools (see Fitzgerald et al. 2018). When staffing is de-centralised, 'hard-to-staff' schools (e.g. rural/remote) become harder to staff leading to an over-representation of inexperienced teachers in these schools. As Gavin and McGrath-Champ (2016) argue, 'such schools experience chronic difficulty in attracting teachers, particularly those considered to be 'quality' as defined by teaching experience and qualification level, and retaining them for any length of time' (259).

Nathan (principal association, National) explained this as a 'residualised' staffing situation where these schools, 'had to ... take anybody that [they] can get'. Nancy (union, Vic), referring to schools in regional Victoria, noted in relation to student welfare, 'the system is struggling to get enough people in specialist school support roles – so psychologists, speech therapists, social workers – who are employed by the department and work regionally'. In a similar vein Delia (union, National) and others made mention of the equity implications associated with the 'different pool of parents' available in 'affluent' schools to be members of the school council and to support the school (in relation to business, financial and legal expertise) that were not available in 'disadvantaged communities'. Considerable time is spent by principals in finding and contracting outsourced services which had previously been provided by government under centralised systems. Ironically, the centralised bureaucracies of the twentieth century had been established on the basis that they would provide a more equitable education across rural and regional schools because they offered a range of services to the local schools across the system.

## Concluding discussion

Consistent with the long-held arguments in the research literature, the data presented in this paper illustrate stakeholders' keen awareness of the resource inequities generated through marketised schooling systems (Blackmore 1999, 2016; Keddle and Mills 2019; Smyth 2011). Competition against external accountabilities produces hierarchies and residualisation within education systems and decentralisation (driven by economic rationalism) reduces material and professional support for schools (Smyth 2011). These processes undermine economic and political justice (Fraser 2009) – i.e. they create a system of winners and losers where some schools receive more resources and are able to have more say over their governance than others. The stakeholders also recognised that to some extent, there is potential for new (or renewed) forms of centralised and regional support to begin to remedy these injustices – e.g. with extra funding and regulation (around staffing and services) as well as regional support, school autonomy

might be mobilised in ways that ameliorate some of the inequities produced within a marketised system (Keddie 2017a).

According to the stakeholders, current central and regional supports for the public education systems within Victoria, NSW and WA are not cognisant enough of the disadvantage experienced by principals and schools amid the convergence of school autonomy reform with the market imperatives of economic efficiency, competition and public accountability. Amid this convergence, principals are finding it difficult to manage the extra responsibilities and pressures of greater school autonomy and accountability; while schools (especially small schools and schools in rural, remote and disadvantaged areas) are experiencing a lack of capacity to mobilise the ‘freedoms’ of this reform in ways that adequately support their students.

While most principals welcome autonomy in decision making for their schools (Thomson and Blackmore 2006), the market imperatives driving this autonomy intensify workload, promote competition between principals and schools and reflect a sense of professional mistrust (Niesche 2018). As we highlighted in this paper, the plight of principals amid these conditions is particularly worrying. The pressures and expectations of the present system mean that it is difficult to recruit school leaders particularly in remote areas. Many principals (especially early career principals) are unprepared with many lacking the requisite skills and capacity to manage their school resources effectively and equitably for their students. A view expressed by many stakeholders was that principals are not provided with adequate centralised and regional support to manage their schools. Equally worrying amid these conditions is the plight of small schools and schools in low socio-economic, rural and remote areas. These schools’ extra and particular needs are not being met by current resourcing initiatives. They tend not to have the same capacity and access to extra support as larger and better resourced schools.

Strengthening the findings of previous research in this space, we reiterate the significance of greater support for principals to mobilise the freedoms of school autonomy in ways that adequately support all students (see Thomson 2009). Given the concerns expressed in this paper, we take particular note of the recommendations in Heffernan and Pierpoint’s (2020) recent report *Autonomy, Accountability, and Principals’ Work*. This report echoes some of the issues raised in this paper and recommends in particular that greater:

... clarity and definition is needed about the role of the principal in the current climate. The role description of the principal should be refined to reflect current requirements and ensure the role is manageable (6).

More clarity and definition we contend is necessary in relation to the issues of budgetary autonomy raised in this paper in the form of greater professional guidance to support principals to manage these funds in transparent, efficient and equitable ways. It is also necessary in relation to the concerns of workload intensity raised – e.g. greater clarity over matters of decision-making, authority and responsibility may alleviate workload and generate efficiencies in task delegation. On the issues of workload intensity and principal shortage, we would also strongly endorse other recommendations in this report (Heffernan and Pierpoint 2020) such as ensuring that principals have access to a diversity of wellbeing programmes and a diversity of on-going and tailored professional development and that more attention be directed at the department level to attract and retain principals (within the context of greater personal and professional supports). Key here,

as Heffernan and Pierpoint (2020) contend, is ensuring that all of these processes privilege the input and voices of principals themselves.

In relation to the negative impacts of devolution on particular schools (small schools, low SES and rural schools), we reiterate the significance of a greater recognition of the particularities of these contexts in the determination and allocation of extra supports. We acknowledge the significance of existing differential funding (at state and national levels) across Australia's public education systems and its support for equity. However, it is clear from the data presented here that such funding requires greater differentiation to better address the enduring challenges of access and resourcing in these contexts associated with rurality and remoteness (see Downes and Roberts 2018) and the increasing systemic inequities and stratification generated through differential capacities for parental contributions to particular public schools (see Rowe and Perry 2020). Rowe and Perry (2020) suggest that the stratified funding inequities currently characterising Australia's public education systems could be reduced through additional sources of funding being available through departmental schemes to socially disadvantaged schools only. They also argue for a regulation or cap of parental contributions to public schools to reduce stratification and residualisation.

These sorts of strategies continue to be crucial in addressing some of the problems and inequities outlined in this paper. However, they are not enough to transform the market imperatives of economic efficiency, competition and public accountability that now permeate the governance of our public school systems. These imperatives in their production and reproduction of inequities are continuing to move public education away from the public good (see Gerrard, 2018). As long as these imperatives are dominant in such governance, there will continue to be 'goal displacement' (as Travis put it) and a compromising of ethical practice within our public education systems. Nearly 10 years ago, Smyth (2011) offered three key propositions for a politically activist view of school autonomy that, given the enduring issues highlighted in this paper about the ongoing degrading impacts associated with the marketisation of education, remain as urgent now as it they were then. We frame them here as closing questions (115–116).

How can we reform the current systems of public education:

- (1) so that schools are not driven by a quest for possessive and competitive individualism within and between themselves but rather a concern for community and collective action?
- (2) so that decisions about schooling are informed much more by educational considerations than those of economics (and) entrepreneurialism?
- (3) so that schools are engaged in questioning what it is they are doing, not from an accountant's point of view, but from the perspective of how their agenda fits with a broader view of what constitutes a just society?

Reform along these lines, that is activist (and not market) focused, seeks to create public education systems where sufficient professional and material resourcing supports greater clarity about the role of principals and schools to prioritise educative and not business imperatives. Such reform is necessary to ensure that schools are able to mobilise their autonomy in socially just ways.

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